BOOKS

Family History

While **Vagabond Princess** mines history for insights into the fascinating life of Babur's daughter, Gulbadan Begum, **Babur: The Chessboard King** attempts to rewrite it

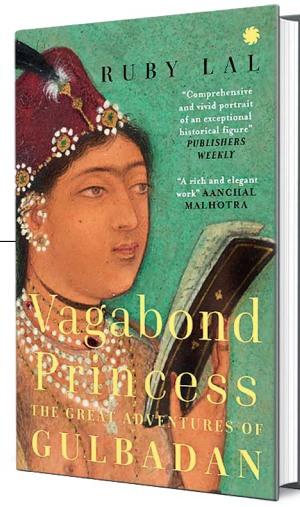
For Mughal aficionados, Gulbadan Begum has a special appeal. While women of power and of literary merit were hardly rare in the Mughal heyday, Gulbadan Begum stands out. Babur's daughter, Humayun's sister and Akbar's aunt sums up her chronology and her status—yet she has had an afterlife of equal significance because she recorded her memories for posterity. It is, Ruby Lal reminds us, the only prose work by a woman emanating from a Muslim court—including the Ottomans, the Safavids and the Mughals.

Gulbadan was ordered by the emperor Akbar to record her memories in 1587. Her account covered Babur's reign in Kabul, the march into Hindustan and the establishment of the Mughals after the battle of Panipat in 1526, Humayun's accession and then his rout at the hands of the resurgent Afghans led by Sher Shah. After 16 years in exile, Humayun regained his kingdom and defeated Sher Shah's successors. Through this churn, Gulbadan, like many other royal ladies, made the long trek from Kabul to the hot plains of north India, was then uprooted from Delhi and found herself back in Kabul, before returning to Delhi. Her writing gives us a sense of the fragility of early Mughal rule.

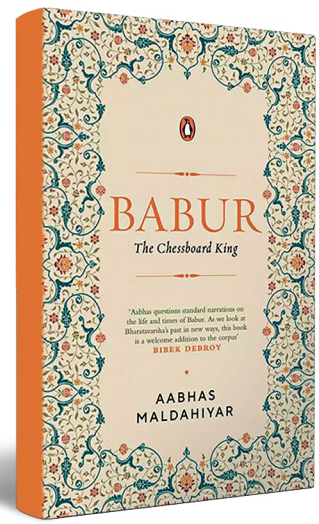
But Gulbadan's book is much more than a listing of Mughal campaigns, victories and defeats. It gives an insight into the Mughal domestic realm and that explains its fascination for Lal. This is to her a chronicle "suffused with feeling", one which "keenly documented childbirth, children killed in war, unfilled desires, anticipation in love and marriage and the simultaneity of war and peace".

Most remarkably, in 1577, she led a group of royal Mughal women on a Haj, undertaking a long sea journey. This star-studded Mughal women's convoy was a unique pageant—"never had a group of royal women travelled this way to Arabia". The return journey was equally full of adventure—including a shipwreck in Aden.

Gulbadan Begum's book had ended abruptly in 1553; possibly, there was more, but it has never been found. Lal's treatment of the years between 1553 and 1587 and thereafter till her death in 1603 is a skilful weaving together of different sources. In Lal's account, the princess appears as a woman of decidedly independent views. The Haj adventure was a spiritual quest, but it was also an assertion of her "vagabond nature" and equally an unwillingness to conform to the discipline of the royal harem. Lal speculates the remainder of the manuscript was suppressed as it did not fit in with the imperial narrative—a project being forged by Akbar's principal courtier Abul Fazl. Plausible or not, this does not



VAGABOND PRINCESS
The Great Adventures of Gulbadan
By Ruby Lal
JUGGERNAUT
₹**699**; **280** pages



BABUR
The Chessboard King (Vol. 1)
By Aabhas Maldahiyar
PENGUIN/VINTAGE
₹**999**; **480** pages